order to counter their vicious propaganda and take the wind out of their sails, the 'crunch issues' raised by the insurgents need to be addressed with despatch by the central and state governments, security forces and administrators, beginning at the grass-roots level.

To tackle the challenge of insurgency and terrorism, it is imperative to create an apex core security group at the national and state levels. It is necessary that such evil must be 'nipped in the bud'. It is easier to do so in the initial stages. This core group should work towards evolving an overall security aim and a counterterrorism strategy.

I am convinced that conventional armies and paramilitary forces need reorientation training to handle terrorism or insurgency. We have accordingly established counterinsurgency institutions in J&K and the northeast. It is being ensured that prior to their induction in a disturbed area, every soldier or unit is put through a specially structured training programme of about eight weeks. Our armed forces have also been carrying out joint training on counterterrorism with foreign armies such as those of the US, Russia, the UK, China, Singapore and other friendly countries. This has been to the mutual benefit of the forces involved. Our police and paramilitary forces have often been outgunned and outmanoeuvred by the Maoists, and have suffered serious reverses in the forested areas of central India, Chattisgarh, West Bengal and Orissa. It is clear that they need to be equipped, trained and led better, and thereby given the capability to successfully wage the campaign against the Maoists and Naxals. It is reassuring to see that many states are modernizing their police force and have created counterterrorism schools for their training, so that they can meet this challenge more effectively.

The people in the conflict zone are the 'centre of gravity' and all operational strategies should be focused on winning their hearts and minds, and their support and cooperation. Actions that demean and alienate the population should be scrupulously avoided. After all, they are the helpless victims caught between two warring sides. Very often, the people would give vent to their feelings and say, 'we are caught in the crossfire between the jehadis and the army. *Jenab,*